New York Travel Guide

The city that never sleeps - United States

New York: Overview and History

New York City is the largest city in the United States and is made up of five boroughs: Manhattan, Brooklyn, Queens, The Bronx and Staten Island. The area was originally the homeland of the Lenape people.

In the 1620s the Dutch founded a colony called New Amsterdam at the southern tip of Manhattan. The English took control in 1664 and renamed it New York. Between 1892 and 1954 millions of immigrants entered the United States through Ellis Island in New York Harbor.

The Statue of Liberty, a gift from France and the people of Paris to the United States, was dedicated in 1886. It was designed by the French sculptor Frederic Auguste Bartholdi, and its iron framework was engineered by Gustave Eiffel, who later built the Eiffel Tower in Paris.

Today New York is a world capital of finance, media, art, fashion and theatre, and the headquarters of the United Nations.

New York: Top Attractions

The Statue of Liberty stands on Liberty Island and can be visited by ferry, together with the Ellis Island National Museum of Immigration. Central Park, designed by Frederick Law Olmsted and Calvert Vaux, covers 843 acres in the middle of Manhattan.

The Empire State Building, completed in 1931, has observation decks on the 86th and 102nd floors. Other great viewpoints include Top of the Rock at Rockefeller Center and the observatory of One World Trade Center, the tallest building in the Western Hemisphere at 1,776 feet (541 metres). The 9/11 Memorial and Museum honours the victims of the 2001 attacks.

The Metropolitan Museum of Art is one of the largest art museums in the world, and the Museum of Modern Art (MoMA) holds famous works such as Van Gogh's The Starry Night.

Times Square is famous for its giant digital billboards and is the heart of the Broadway theatre district. Walking across the Brooklyn Bridge, opened in 1883, and along the High Line, a park built on an old elevated railway, are free and memorable experiences.

New York: Neighborhoods and Food

SoHo is known for its cast-iron buildings and shopping, and Greenwich Village for its jazz clubs and Washington Square Park. Harlem is the historic centre of African-American culture and home of the Apollo Theater.

In Brooklyn, DUMBO offers classic views of the Manhattan skyline beneath the Brooklyn Bridge, and Williamsburg is a hip area of bars, music venues and markets. Chinatown, Little Italy and Flushing in Queens offer some of the best Asian and Italian food in the city.

New York is famous for its foldable thin-crust New York-style pizza slices and for bagels with cream cheese and lox (smoked salmon). Katz's Delicatessen, open since 1888, serves a legendary pastrami on rye sandwich.

Other classics include New York cheesecake, hot dogs from street carts, and halal cart chicken over rice. Tipping 18 to 20 percent is expected in restaurants.

New York: Getting Around and Practical Tips

The New York City Subway runs 24 hours a day, every day. Pay by tapping a contactless card or phone at the OMNY readers; a single ride costs about 3 dollars. Yellow taxis, buses and Citi Bike bicycles are also available, and the Staten Island Ferry is free and passes the Statue of Liberty.

New York has three major airports. JFK International Airport is the main airport for international flights and is connected to the subway by the AirTrain. LaGuardia serves mostly domestic flights, and Newark Airport is in New Jersey. Flights from New York to London take about 7 hours, and Singapore Airlines flies non-stop between Newark and Singapore.

The currency is the US dollar (USD). Sales tax is added at the till, so prices on tags are lower than what you pay.

The best times to visit New York are spring, April to June, and autumn, September to November. The holiday season in December is magical, with the Rockefeller Center Christmas tree and ice skating, but it is cold. Summers are hot and humid.

New York: Sample Itinerary and Day Trips

Day 1: Take the ferry to the Statue of Liberty and Ellis Island, visit the 9/11 Memorial and walk across the Brooklyn Bridge to DUMBO. Day 2: Visit the Metropolitan Museum of Art, walk through Central Park, and see a Broadway show near Times Square in the evening.

Day 3: Walk the High Line, explore Greenwich Village and SoHo, and watch the sunset from the Empire State Building or Top of the Rock.

The Hudson Valley, north of the city, offers historic estates, art museums and autumn colours. Amtrak trains reach Philadelphia in about 1 hour 20 minutes and Washington DC in about 3 hours. In summer, the beaches of Long Island and the Hamptons are popular escapes.

New York is a natural starting point for a transatlantic trip to London or Paris.